

Trance

With a talking clarinet, Cindy Tran can hit high notes and new lows.



SYNOPSIS

Set in 1999 Michigan, Cindy Tran is a chaotic freshman who finds peace in the lamest of all instruments: the clarinet. She hopes to rank in the Rogers High School band. Really, she needs to hear her parents say, “I’m proud.” When her clarinet breaks before auditions, she takes an old clarinet left behind in a memorialized locker after its owner went missing decades ago. Now, this lame instrument is helping this shy Vietnamese American teenager get into homecoming court and brainwash the masses into killing the music teacher. Those who get in the clarinet’s way will sing the swan song.

It is a coming-of-age story about the messy pursuit to belong, exploring how a 14-year-old Vietnamese American girl navigates competition, changing friendships, and the weight of immigrant family relationships.

WHY NOW?

Trance taps into the cultural appetite for pre-smartphone nostalgia to explore the timeless social pressures of high school. It flips the standard coming-of-age narrative on its head by delivering a fresh perspective on a chaotic Vietnamese American protagonist. By focusing on a teenager who makes wildly dark and terrible choices under pressure, the project directly addresses the timely conversation surrounding mental health, the desire to belong, and the weight of immigrant family expectations.

Trance is the absurdity of *Operation Mincemeat* meets the dark comedy of *Heathers* meets the immigrant struggles of *In the Heights*.

CAST OF CHARACTERS

CINDY TRAN is a chaotic, insecure 14-year-old freshman desperately seeking validation.

CALVIN TRAN is the sharp-tongued older brother of Cindy. He sees right through Cindy's sudden popularity boost.

VINH TRAN is the father of Cindy and Calvin. Born in Vietnam, he is an automotive worker who also must carry the heavy weight of providing for his family.

VY TRINH is the mother of Cindy and Calvin. Born in Vietnam, She is the grounding force of the household, trying to bridge the cultural gap between her chaotic teenagers and traditional roots.

ROGERS HIGH SCHOOL

MUSIC TEACHER is the target of the clarinet.

MISSING STUDENT is the original owner of the clarinet who vanished decades ago.